1. DINK SMALLWOOD

What It Is

You are Dink Smallwood, just another simpleton in a small village and performing simple chores like tending to your pig farm and helping out the village folk doing petty chores. However things change fast, as once, when coming back from your chores, you find out that your house is burnt and your mother is no longer in this world. After the grievous incident, you venture farther from the village and encounter a horde of adventures while becoming famous along the way, going on from being a no name pig farmer to the saviour of the world and whatnot. The story seems to be something straight out of a classic fantasy book, complete with kings, castles, goblins, demons, flying dragons and tiny magicians wearing pointed hats to complete the recipe.

Played in an RPG setting, as you interact with characters in the game and complete quests, you gain experience and upgrade potions for attack, defence, and magic...and of course, the usual inventory where you can equip yourself with swords, bows, bombs, potions and spells to help you stand up against your bloodthirsty enemies. Even the music is nostalgic, reminding you what it was like gaming in the old times, and of course, the cheesy humour to go along with it to constantly remind you that it's a game you are playing after all.

Why It's Addictive

RPG games are notoriously known for their effectiveness for pulling the players inside their world. *Dink Smallwood* is no exception to this rule and does this rather well, you will be craving for the next quest or to see the area which you can't explore yet or can't wait to interact with the next merchant offering newer items (Vorpal sword with an attack rating of 835692 anyone?). Looking for secret areas alone, will take a huge chunk of your time, but in the end, it's all worth it. While the amount of inventory items is not particularly high, they are rare, which gives you that satisfying feeling of accomplishment when you finally get one. Even the enemies get crazily tough as you progress, forcing you to spend a good amount of time towards upgrading your abilities before engaging them.

The main story is rather long, keeping you hooked on it as you are constantly kept wondering "What's next?" The world's size is rather big, the map you acquire later in the game doesn't do justice to the area, and it brings out the true definition of small-scale maps. You will constantly want to finish off all quests in the current area possible to advance to the next. Even if you complete the main story and are left hungry thereafter, you can always download add-ons free from the developer's Web site, or make your own maps with the included editor. This small 16 MB game will keep you busy for days while you are cut off from the rest of the world.

Final words

As you may already have seen from the list, a game needn't have DirectX 10 graphics or a Havok 2 physics engine, or make a dent of Rs 1,000 in your wallet to be fun. Games, at the end of the day, are just games, and even ones with mediocre graphics will grab your attention with superior gameplay, compared to something that will run on a box only Russian Czars and BIll Gates' relatives could afford, but fail to grab your interest because of boring gameplay! □

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